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I Love My Baby. I Miss Myself.

For the new mom who'd die for her baby —
and can't find herself anywhere.

You love her more than your life. And you don't recognize the woman holding her.

You would walk into traffic for this baby. And also: some nights you sit there, milk-stained and hollow-eyed and touched-out to the point of rage, and think — *where did I go?* Then the guilt comes, because what kind of mother feels like this?

This kind. The honest kind. Becoming a mother doesn't just add a baby — it detonates your old identity, your body, your sleep, your friendships, your name. There's even a word for it: **matrescence**, the brutal becoming nobody warns you about. The grief you feel is not regret. The resentment is not failure. The two truths — "I adore her" and "I've lost myself" — live in the same chest at the same time, and both are real.

This isn't a "cherish every moment" guilt-trip. It's permission to grieve the woman you were, and a real plan to start getting her back — ten minutes at a time.

SAY IT OUT LOUD

"I can love my baby completely and still miss my old life." That sentence is not a betrayal of her. It's the first honest thing you've let yourself feel in months.

STEP 1

Name what you lost

You can't get yourself back if you won't admit what went missing. This isn't ingratitude — it's grief, and grief needs to be named to move. What do you miss?

- **Your body** — the one that fit your clothes and felt like home without a second thought.
- **Your name** — being a whole person, not just "the baby's mom" to the entire world.
- **Your freedom** — leaving the house in five minutes, a quiet coffee, a thought finished without interruption.
- **Your friendships** — the texts you can't answer, the woman you used to be with them.
- **Your sleep, your spontaneity, your sense of who you are** when no one is physically attached to you.

BOTH ARE TRUE

Grief and gratitude share the same heart. Mourning your old life doesn't shrink your love for her by one ounce. Let yourself miss it — that's how you stop drowning in it.

STEP 2

The 10-minute you

You don't need a spa day or a babysitter. You need tiny, daily deposits back into yourself before there's nothing left to withdraw. Do one a day — they count:

- 1 **Drink it hot.** One coffee or tea, sitting down, while it's still warm. A small act of "I exist too."

- 2 **Play one song that was YOURS.** Before you were anyone's mom. Loud. In the kitchen. Let your body remember her.

- 3 **Get dressed in real clothes.** Not for anyone — for you. It changes how you feel in your own skin in five minutes.

- 4 **Text a friend like the old you.** Not a logistics text. A real one. Reach for the woman, not just the mom-network.

- 5 **Ten minutes of a thing you love.** A book, a sketch, a show, the sun on your face. Reclaiming a sliver of yourself is not selfish — it's survival.

STEP 3

Ask for help without the guilt

Needing help doesn't make you less of a mother. Martyrdom isn't love — it's a slow drain. Stop hinting and use the words:

“ **TO YOUR PARTNER — OWNERSHIP**

Tonight you own bath and bedtime — fully, start to finish, while I leave the room and rest. Not "help." Own it.

“ **CLAIM AN HOUR**

I need one hour to myself this weekend. Take the baby and don't text me unless it's an emergency.

“ **THE MENTAL-LOAD HANDOFF**

When you ask what you can do, the answer is: take a whole category off my plate without me having to manage it. Pick diapers, or nights, or bottles.

“ **WHEN YOU'RE NOT OKAY**

I'm not okay today and I need backup. That's not me failing — that's me telling the truth and asking for help.

WHY "OWN," NOT "HELP"

"Help me with the baby" leaves you the manager, still tracking it all. "Tonight is yours" actually takes the weight off. Hand over whole jobs, not little tasks.

The lies new-motherhood tells you

That guilty voice is loud and wrong. Trade each lie for the truth:

THE LIE

"A good mom loves every minute."

THE TRUTH

Good moms have bored, lonely, furious minutes. Loving her doesn't mean loving every second of the work.

THE LIE

"Needing time away = selfish."

THE TRUTH

A refilled mom has more to give. Time for you *is* time for her.

THE LIE

"Everyone else has it together."

THE TRUTH

They don't. They're just not posting the 3 a.m. tears and the touched-out rage.

THE LIE

"Feeling this way means something's wrong with me."

THE TRUTH

It means you're a human in the hardest transition of your life — on no sleep.

You didn't lose her. She's just holding a baby.

Read these on the hard days. They're true:

- I can love my baby and still grieve my old life.
- I don't have to disappear to be a good mother.
- Taking care of me is part of taking care of her.
- I am becoming, not broken.
- The woman I was is still in here — and she's allowed to take up space again.

Please read this carefully: if the sadness, numbness, anxiety, rage, or hopelessness is constant — not just hard days — or you have scary or intrusive thoughts, that may be postpartum depression or anxiety. It is common and very treatable, and it is not your fault. Call your doctor, or in the U.S. the Postpartum Support International helpline: **1-800-944-4773** (call or text). Reaching out is the bravest, best-mom thing you can do.

She would rather have a whole you than a perfect mom.

Ten minutes at a time, you come back to yourself — not the old you, the bigger one who survived this. Loving her and keeping you were never a choice you had to make. Drink it hot. Play the song. Ask for the hour. You're still in there, and she's worth coming back for.

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